

Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda was supposed to have been the runaway leader and the assembly elections a one-horse race ("The Gamble That Failed", November 2). But the voters have silenced everyone. Hooda's gamble of early elections did not pay off. The surprise element in Haryana has been the impressive showing of Chautala's INLD. As for the Congress, had the Opposition not been divided, it would have been in deeper trouble.

DILBAG RAI, Chandigarh

Coaching Blues

We do not have the culture of accountability or Venkatesh Prasad and Robin Singh would have resigned on their own ("Eggstreme Tendencies", November 2). As a bowling coach, Venky saw our medium pacers slowing down from 140 kmph to 120. Even Harbhajan Singh lost his sting. Our fielding which was never great sank to new lows while Robin Singh remained our coach and was expected to do wonders. It is indeed wrong to hold coaches responsible for inveterate laggards but then why have coaches if they cannot make a difference.

ASHOK KARNIK, Mumbai

Food for Thought

While the West is busy banning all types of food which contribute to obesity in children, it's high

time we too become more responsible in giving the growing child food items that contribute to his physical and mental development ("How Healthy is Your Child?" November 2). The Government can contribute to the kitty of good health by subsidising the exorbitant prices of fruits, vegetables and other food items.

SUMAN PAI, Kanhangad, Kerala



“ Madhu Koda presented a picture of tribal simplicity and innocence. But the amount of money involved in the scam and its spread is undoubtedly stunning. ”

KRSNA KARNA, Patna

Red Trouble

The Central Government has now realised the incapability of the West Bengal Government to contain the Naxal menace which is growing ominously ("Tackling the Red Terror", October 26). It is good that the home minister is in full control of the operation to wipe

out the Naxal menace. He deserves kudos for such a bold step. It is now clear that West Bengal's strategy of settling the Naxal movement through dialogue has not reaped any plausible result.

LT. COL (RETD) RANJIT SINHA, Deolali, Maharashtra

Bride and Prejudice

People in Haryana have no one but themselves to blame for the "skewed sex ratio" which has resulted

in a desperate situation where there are not enough brides for the men ("Desperate Husbands", October 12). Their obsession with sons and aversion for daughters led them to large scale female infanticide, and they are now paying the price.

RANJANA MANCHANDA, via www.indiatoday.in

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YEARS
AGO IN
INDIA
TODAY

JANUARY 1-15, 1980

Sex and Politics

The clamour for equal rights and women's lib in India gains momentum with the International Women's Year. Yet, the number of women aspirants for Lok Sabha seats remains extremely low. While there are 48 women voters for every 100 contestants, the number of women candidates has never been more than 3 out of every 100 contestants in the Parliamentary elections. There are 149 women contestants this time as against 70 in 1977, constituting barely 3.2 per cent of the 4,633 candidates in the fray. Interestingly, women's representation in the highest legislative body of the country has been on the decline since 1967. The number of women members in Parliament—which increased from 27 in 1957 to 35 in 1962—declined to 30 in 1967, 21 in 1971, and 19 in 1977, though the number of contestants increased from 45 in 1957, 50 in 1977 and 149 in 1980. An interesting feature about women in politics is that the same old faces have been seeking the people's mandate in each subsequent election. Half of the 149 women candidates making their bid to enter Parliament from 21 states and eight Union territories are the ones who either lost or won in the last three elections.

by Prabhu Chawla

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